STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

70-20-10: HOW LEADERS DEVELOP

Where 70-20-10 comes from, what 191 executives named, the five experiences CCL finds in four countries, why challenge needs feedback, ten challenges in a job, and a development card.

616 key events of their careers, described by 191 executives: the data of the research from which 70-20-10 later emerged.

LINDSEY, HOMES & MCCALL, 1987

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Few leaders are made in a classroom. 70-20-10 says so in three numbers, and few rules in leadership development are quoted more often. Where do the numbers come from, what do the data behind them show, and what can a manager do with them?

In 1996 Michael Lombardo and Robert Eichinger wrote that successful managers learn roughly 70% from tough jobs, 20% from people and 10% from courses and reading. Behind it lies research by the Center for Creative Leadership, in which 191 executives described 616 key events of their careers. A 2018 review found the evidence for the 70% weak. Studies show that challenge teaches up to a point, that feedback keeps it useful, and where 70-20-10 goes wrong in practice.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Where 70-20-10 comes from

The rule has no study of its own. Its best-known source is one sentence in The Career Architect Development Planner of 1996: lessons learned by successful and effective managers come “roughly” 70% from tough jobs, 20% from people, mostly the boss, and 10% from courses and reading.

1981–82

Three CCL researchers and four corporations start asking executives how they developed.

1987

CCL's technical report: 191 executives, 616 key events, 1,547 lessons.

1988

McCall, Lombardo and Morrison tell the findings in The Lessons of Experience.

1996

Lombardo and Eichinger: “roughly” 70, 20 and 10.

The 191 were seen by their companies as high potentials or as having lived up to their potential. Each named at least three events that lastingly changed how they managed, and what they learned. The researchers warned that the sample may not stand for all executives, and that all of it was self-report.

OUR READING

70-20-10 sums up what successful executives remembered about their careers. It does not measure how much anyone learns where.

Sources: Michael M. Lombardo & Robert W. Eichinger, Lominger, 1996 (via Charles Jennings, 2011); Esther H. Lindsey, Virginia Homes & Morgan W. McCall, Jr., Center for Creative Leadership, 1987

The 1996 sentence is confirmed only through independent summaries; we could not see the book. How the three numbers were derived from the data is not shown in any source we could check.

THE NUMBERS

What 191 executives named

The 1987 technical report gives the number of events of each kind. Grouped as the report groups them, challenging assignments are the largest block, but not 70%.

THE 616 KEY EVENTS, IN THE REPORT'S GROUPS (SHARE OF EVENTS)



Count hardships, early jobs and first supervision as work too, and the split becomes 73% work, 18% people and 6% courses: close to 70-20-10. Whether Lombardo and Eichinger grouped the events this way, the sources we checked do not say. The shares count events that people remembered, not hours of learning.

OUR READING

The same data give 48% or 73%, depending on what counts as a job.

Source: Esther H. Lindsey, Virginia Homes & Morgan W. McCall, Jr., Center for Creative Leadership, 1987

Shares worked out by the editors from the event counts in the report (616 events), rounded. Executives from six large corporations, data from the 1980s.

THE MODEL

Three sources, five experiences

The Center for Creative Leadership presents 70-20-10 as a guideline with three clusters of experience. In a 2016 white paper it also names what the rule leaves out.

01
Challenging assignments
new, difficult work that stretches the person

02
Developmental relationships
bosses who teach, model, push and mentor

03
Coursework and training
in CCL's view, an amplifier of the other two

THE BASIC FIVE: EXPERIENCES THAT TEACH LEADERSHIP IN ALL FOUR COUNTRIES (CCL, 2016)

01	02	03	04	05
Bosses and superiors	Turnarounds	Increases in scope	Horizontal moves	New initiatives

CCL asked 393 top and senior executives in China, India, Singapore and the United States. Each of the five was cited by at least 20% of interviewees in three of the four countries; coursework and training by only 9–15%. CCL also notes that the rule says neither which experiences teach most nor what each one teaches.

OUR READING

The ratio says little. The list of experiences says more, and it can be planned.

Sources: Center for Creative Leadership, 2025; Meena Surie Wilson, Ellen Van Velsor, Anand Chandrasekar & Corey Criswell, Center for Creative Leadership, 2016

Interviews from 2005 to 2009: 234 in the United States, 71 in India, 54 in China, 34 in Singapore; self-reports. CCL calls 70-20-10 research-based but does not show how the ratio was calculated.

More in the essay Leadership without a title

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Challenge teaches, up to a point

D. Scott DeRue and Ned Wellman studied 225 on-the-job experiences of 60 managers. Leadership skills grew with the challenge of an experience, but with diminishing returns; access to feedback offset the decline at high levels of challenge.

In the Australian public sector, Samantha Johnson, Deborah Blackman and Fiona Buick found middle managers willing to keep learning, yet 70-20-10 was not building the capability it promised. They name four misconceptions:

Four misconceptions in practice (Johnson et al., 2018)

1. unstructured experience will build capability by itself
2. social learning, read too narrowly
3. behaviour will change after a course, without active support
4. the three parts need not be planned together

Alan Clardy reviewed five strands of literature in 2018. The evidence that 70% or more of learning at work is informal is weak, he concludes, and the rule should be set aside.

OUR READING

Experience alone makes no plan. Stretch, feedback and a course chosen for the job have to be put together deliberately.

Sources: D. Scott DeRue & Ned Wellman, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2009; Samantha J. Johnson, Deborah A. Blackman & Fiona Buick, Human Resource Development Quarterly, 2018; Alan Clardy, Human Resource Development Review, 2018

DeRue and Wellman: one study with 60 managers. Johnson et al.: qualitative data from one public sector. Clardy reviews the claim about informal learning at work in general, not only for leaders.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

How much does a job teach?

Instead of shares, CCL's research counts challenges. Cynthia McCauley lists ten that make an assignment developmental; many can be added to a current job without changing it.

The task	The people
Unfamiliar responsibilities	Problems with employees
New directions	External pressure
Inherited problems	Influence without authority
High stakes	Work across cultures
Scope and scale	Work group diversity

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEADER

Assignment	move the returns area to a new hall within six weeks
Challenges	unfamiliar responsibilities, high stakes, influence without authority
Feedback	the site manager every Friday, a peer from the other shift

Three challenges, with feedback every week. The case is made up.

Sources: Cynthia D. McCauley, Center for Creative Leadership, 2006 (via Leadership Now, 2006); D. Scott DeRue & Ned Wellman, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2009

List after McCauley (2006); the two groups are the editors'. More challenge is not always better: after DeRue and Wellman, add feedback before adding challenge.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The development card

One skill per card, filled in with your manager. If the gap shows in a KPI, first check that it is a matter of skill at all.

01 The skill one, as others would see it: what will I do differently?

02 The assignment a real piece of work, and which of the ten challenges it holds

03 Feedback from whom, how often, and the first date

04 Someone to learn from a boss, a peer or a mentor who does it well

05 Course or reading only what supports the assignment, and when

06 What I learned after 90 days: what changed, and what comes next

Sources: Center for Creative Leadership, 2025; D. Scott DeRue & Ned Wellman, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2009; Samantha J. Johnson, Deborah A. Blackman & Fiona Buick, Human Resource Development Quarterly, 2018

A practice proposed by the editors, after CCL's three sources, DeRue & Wellman (2009) on feedback and Johnson et al. (2018) on planning the parts together. No ratio is prescribed.

Open the tool: KPI Diagnostic stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Career Architect Development Planner
Michael M. Lombardo & Robert W. Eichinger, Lominger, 1996 · via Charles Jennings, 2011
https://charles-jennings.blogspot.com/2011/08/social-workplace-learning-through.html

Key Events in Executives' Lives (Technical Report No. 32)
Esther H. Lindsey, Virginia Homes & Morgan W. McCall, Jr., Center for Creative Leadership, 1987
https://www.ccl.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/02/key-events-in-executives-lives-research-paper-center-for-creative-leadership.pdf

The 70-20-10 Rule for Leadership Development
Center for Creative Leadership, 2025
https://www.ccl.org/articles/leading-effectively-articles/70-20-10-rule/

Grooming Top Leaders: Cultural Perspectives from China, India, Singapore, and the United States
Meena Surie Wilson, Ellen Van Velsor, Anand Chandrasekar & Corey Criswell, Center for Creative Leadership, 2016
https://cclinnovation.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/02/groomingtopleaders.pdf

Developing leaders via experience: The role of developmental challenge, learning orientation, and feedback availability
D. Scott DeRue & Ned Wellman, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2009
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/19594230/

The 70:20:10 framework and the transfer of learning
Samantha J. Johnson, Deborah A. Blackman & Fiona Buick, Human Resource Development Quarterly, 2018
https://doi.org/10.1002/hrdq.21330

70-20-10 and the Dominance of Informal Learning: A Fact in Search of Evidence
Alan Clardy, Human Resource Development Review, 2018
https://doi.org/10.1177/1534484318759399

Developmental Assignments: Creating Learning Experiences without Changing Jobs
Cynthia D. McCauley, Center for Creative Leadership, 2006 · via Leadership Now, 2006
https://www.leadershipnow.com/leadingblog/2006/11/how_to_enhance_your_potential.html

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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